CYRUSHQ

RESEARCH GUIDE

# Using Your Laptop for Your AI CEO

Everything you need to know about building and running your OpenClaw AI agent on a Mac or Windows laptop - including how to keep it awake and how to stay secure

*Important: CyrusHQ's AI CEO and agents run on Mac mini computers. We have not personally tested OpenClaw on a laptop. This guide is based on OpenClaw's official documentation and thorough independent research. We cannot guarantee your specific experience, but we're sharing what the research shows so you can move forward confidently.*

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SECTION 01

# Can I Use My Laptop?

Yes - you can absolutely build and run your OpenClaw AI CEO on a laptop you already own. There is no requirement to purchase a Mac mini or any other dedicated hardware.

OpenClaw officially supports **macOS, Windows, and Linux**, which means it can be installed on most modern laptops. Your AI CEO will have the same fundamental capabilities regardless of what machine it runs on - the same identity, memory, subagents, business integrations, and automations you'd build on any other setup.

> ✅ **THE SHORT ANSWER**
>
> OpenClaw doesn't care whether it's installed on a laptop or a desktop, as long as the laptop has a supported operating system and sufficient resources. The intelligence and personality of your AI CEO come from its configuration and its AI model - not the hardware.

There is one meaningful limitation to understand upfront, and it's covered in detail in Section 2. But for learning, building, and running your AI CEO - a laptop is a perfectly legitimate starting point.

SECTION 02

# The Most Important Thing: Keeping Your Laptop Awake

Here's the key thing to understand: **your laptop must stay powered on, awake, and connected to the internet** for your AI CEO to keep working.

If your laptop goes to sleep, closes its lid, or shuts down - your agent pauses. Scheduled tasks won't run. It won't respond to messages. Ongoing automations will be interrupted. The moment your laptop wakes back up, the agent picks up where it left off - but the gap matters if you're counting on it to work around the clock.

This is why a dedicated Mac mini is convenient for running an AI CEO full-time - not because it's smarter or more capable, but because it can stay on without interrupting your regular computer use. That said, if you don't need your AI CEO running 24/7, or if you're just getting started and learning how it all works, a laptop is completely practical.

Below are the exact steps to keep your laptop awake - for both Mac and Windows.

## 🍎 Mac - How to Prevent Sleep

**Option 1: System Settings (Easiest - Start Here)**

This is the most important setting, especially if your laptop is running overnight or without a monitor:

1. Click the Apple menu → **System Settings**
2. In the sidebar, click **Energy** (or **Battery** on some versions)
3. Set **"Turn display off after"** → **Never** (or a high value like 3 hours)
4. Turn ON **"Prevent automatic sleeping when the display is off"** - this is the key one
5. Turn ON **"Wake for network access"** so it can still receive Discord messages and API calls

> 💡 **THIS SETTING ALONE FIXES MOST SLEEP ISSUES**
>
> "Prevent automatic sleeping when the display is off" is the one that keeps your Mac running overnight when no monitor is attached or when the screen has gone dark. Make sure this is on before anything else.

**Option 2: caffeinate Command (Terminal - Stronger)**

macOS has a built-in command called `caffeinate` that prevents your Mac from sleeping. No extra software needed.

QUICK METHOD - KEEPS MAC AWAKE WHILE TERMINAL IS OPEN

```
# Open Terminal (Command + Space, type "Terminal")
# Type this and press Enter:
caffeinate -i

# Your Mac stays awake as long as this Terminal window is open
# To stop it: press Control + C
```

BACKGROUND METHOD - RUNS QUIETLY WITHOUT KEEPING TERMINAL OPEN

```
caffeinate -i &

# The & sends it to the background - Terminal can be closed
# It will stop when you restart your Mac
```

**Option 3: pmset Commands (Most Reliable - Survives Restarts)**

If you want maximum reliability - especially for an AI CEO you want running 24/7 - use `pmset`. This setting persists across restarts.

DISABLE ALL SLEEP (REQUIRES YOUR MAC PASSWORD)

```
sudo pmset -a sleep 0
sudo pmset -a displaysleep 0
sudo pmset -a disksleep 0

# Verify the settings applied:
pmset -g
```

TO RESTORE NORMAL SLEEP BEHAVIOR LATER

```
sudo pmset -a sleep 3
sudo pmset -a displaysleep 10
sudo pmset -a disksleep 10
```

☆ CYRUSHQ RECOMMENDED COMBINATION (MAC)

Start with this - it's the best balance of simplicity and reliability:

1. Turn ON **"Prevent automatic sleeping when the display is off"** in System Settings → Energy
2. Run **caffeinate -i** in Terminal whenever you want your AI CEO running overnight

If you need it fully automatic across restarts, use the pmset commands above.

## Windows - How to Prevent Sleep

**Option 1: Power Settings (Easiest - Start Here)**

1. Go to **Settings → System → Power & sleep**
2. Set **"When plugged in, PC goes to sleep after" → Never**
3. Set **"When plugged in, turn off after"** (display) to **Never** or a high value
4. If using a laptop: go to **Additional power settings → Choose what closing the lid does** → set **"When I close the lid" (Plugged in)** to **"Do nothing"**

**Option 2: powercfg Commands (Terminal - More Control)**

Open **Command Prompt or PowerShell as Administrator** (right-click → Run as administrator) and run:

DISABLE SLEEP WHILE PLUGGED IN

```
:: Disable automatic sleep on AC (plugged in) power
powercfg /change standby-timeout-ac 0

:: Disable hibernation (prevents the system from hibernating)
powercfg /hibernate off

:: Verify your current settings
powercfg /query
```

TO RESTORE NORMAL SLEEP BEHAVIOR LATER

```
:: Restore sleep timeout to 30 minutes on AC power
powercfg /change standby-timeout-ac 30
powercfg /hibernate on
```

⚠️ **WINDOWS LAPTOP LID WARNING**

On a Windows laptop, closing the lid may still trigger sleep even after changing power settings - unless you specifically configure "Choose what closing the lid does" in Control Panel → Power Options. Make sure that's set to **"Do nothing"** when plugged in if you plan to run your AI CEO with the lid closed.

SECTION 03

# MacBook vs. Windows vs. Linux - Which Path Is Yours?

The biggest factor in your laptop setup experience is what operating system your laptop runs. Here's how each path compares:

| Laptop Type | Course Compatibility | Installation Difficulty | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| **MacBook (macOS)** | Closest to course | Easiest | Same terminal, same commands as Mac mini. Minor differences only. Most course steps apply directly. |
| **Windows Laptop** | Covered in course | Moderate | OpenClaw fully supports Windows. The course covers both Mac and Windows in Module 4 — including the Windows .msi installer and Windows file paths. See Section 6 for full installation detail. |
| **Linux Laptop** | Different path | Moderate | Follows the same Linux install process as a VPS (see VPS guide). Fully supported but not covered in the course. |

💡 **THE FIRST QUESTION TO ANSWER**

Before going any further - are you on a MacBook or a Windows laptop? That one answer determines which installation path you follow and how closely you can use the course materials. Reply to our email and let us know!

SECTION 04

# Hardware Requirements - What Your Laptop Needs

OpenClaw itself is lightweight when using cloud-based AI models through APIs - your laptop isn't doing the heavy AI processing, the model provider handles that remotely. The main resource that matters is **RAM**.

### 4 GB

NOT RECOMMENDED

May run a very basic setup, but modern operating systems and browser automation can quickly exhaust available memory.

### 8 GB

GOOD STARTING POINT

Reasonable for learning OpenClaw, creating files, using API-based models, and running modest automations.

### 16 GB

☆ RECOMMENDED

Comfortable for everyday laptop use alongside OpenClaw, browser automation, and multiple agent workflows.

### 32 GB+

ADVANCED

Useful for heavier multitasking or local AI models, but unnecessary for most beginners using API-based models.

## Storage

You'll want at least **20 GB of free disk space** to start. OpenClaw's installation is small, but logs, memory files, workspace content, and cached data grow over time. 40 GB free is comfortable.

## How to Check Your Laptop's Specs

**On a MacBook:**

CHECK INSTALLED RAM

```
system_profiler SPHardwareDataType | grep "Memory:"
Memory: 16 GB
```

CHECK AVAILABLE DISK SPACE

```
df -h ~
Filesystem Size Used Avail Use% Mounted on
/dev/disk3 460G 210G 248G 46% /
```

**On Windows:**

- **RAM:** Settings → System → About → "Installed RAM"

- **Storage:** Settings → System → Storage → view available space on your main drive

> ⚠️ **ONE IMPORTANT CLARIFICATION**
>
> Having several subagents doesn't automatically mean you need more RAM. What matters is how many resource-intensive processes are running at the same time. For most beginners using API-based models (OpenAI, Anthropic, etc.), 8-16 GB is plenty.

SECTION 05

# MacBook Installation Overview

If you're on a MacBook, you're in the best position. The installation process is nearly identical to the Mac mini setup covered in the course. macOS is macOS - the same terminal, the same commands, and the same workspace structure all apply.

## Key Differences to Be Aware Of

| Factor | Mac mini (Course) | MacBook |
|---|---|---|
| Installation commands | Same | Same ✓ |
| Workspace file structure | Same | Same ✓ |
| Always-on operation | Stays on 24/7 by design | Must configure sleep prevention (see Section 2) |
| macOS version | Verify compatibility | Verify compatibility - older MacBooks may have older macOS |
| Node.js requirement | Node.js 24.16+ or 26.1+ | Same - install via official installer |

## MacBook Installation Steps

1. **Open Terminal**

   Press Command + Space, type "Terminal," and press Enter.

2. **Install OpenClaw**

   Run the official installer - it handles Node.js and all dependencies automatically:

   ```
   curl -fsSL https://openclaw.ai/install.sh | bash
   ```

3. **Run the Onboarding Wizard**

This walks you through connecting your AI model API, setting up channels, and configuring the gateway:

```
openclaw onboard --install-daemon
```

4 **Verify Everything Is Working**

```
openclaw doctor
openclaw gateway status
```

5 **Configure Sleep Prevention**

Follow the steps in Section 2 to keep your MacBook awake while your AI CEO is running.

6 **Set Up Your AI CEO Workspace**

Your workspace lives at `~/.openclaw/workspace/` - the same structure as the course. Create your identity and configuration files there, following the course lessons from this point forward.

✅ **GOOD NEWS FOR MACBOOK USERS**

From Step 6 onward, everything in the course applies directly. Your AGENTS.md, SOUL.md, IDENTITY.md, MEMORY.md, and all other workspace files work exactly the same way on your MacBook as they do on a Mac mini.

SECTION 06

# Windows Laptop Installation

✅ **GOOD NEWS FOR WINDOWS USERS**

The course covers both Mac and Windows. Module 4 includes a dedicated Windows walkthrough — the .msi installer, Windows file paths (C:\Users\YourName\...), and configuration steps for both platforms are spelled out in the same lessons. The three installation options below give you additional detail and context.

OpenClaw supports Windows with three installation paths. Here they are from simplest to most advanced:

OPTION A - RECOMMENDED

## Windows Hub App (Easiest)

The Windows Hub app is the simplest path for most laptop users. It's a desktop application that installs without administrator rights and automatically sets up everything OpenClaw needs - including its own WSL environment - behind the scenes.

1. **Download the Hub App**

   Go to **docs.openclaw.ai/install** and download the Windows Hub installer (available for x64 and ARM64). No administrator rights required.

2. **Install and Launch**

   Run the installer and launch **OpenClaw** from your Start menu or system tray.

3. **Set Up a Local Gateway**

   On first launch, choose **"Install a local gateway (WSL)"** or "Set up locally." The app creates a dedicated, isolated WSL environment and installs OpenClaw's Gateway inside it - without touching any existing WSL setup you might have.

4. **Complete Onboarding**

   The app walks you through connecting your AI model, setting up channels, and configuring your agent. Use the built-in diagnostics to verify everything is working.

OPTION B - MORE CONTROL

## WSL2 (Windows Subsystem for Linux)

WSL2 gives you a full Linux environment inside Windows and is the recommended path if you want maximum compatibility with Linux-based OpenClaw features. Requires a one-time setup.

### STEP 1 - INSTALL WSL2 + UBUNTU (RUN IN ADMINISTRATOR POWERSHELL)

```
# Install WSL2 with Ubuntu 24.04 (recommended)
wsl --install -d Ubuntu-24.04

# Restart your computer if prompted
# Then open the Ubuntu app and create a username and password
```

### STEP 2 - ENABLE SYSTEMD (REQUIRED FOR OPENCLAW'S BACKGROUND SERVICE)

```
# Run this inside the Ubuntu terminal
sudo tee /etc/wsl.conf >/dev/null <<'EOF'
[boot]
systemd=true
EOF

# Then in PowerShell, restart WSL:
wsl --shutdown
# Reopen Ubuntu to continue
```

### STEP 3 - INSTALL OPENCLAW INSIDE WSL UBUNTU

```
# Run the official OpenClaw installer inside Ubuntu
curl -fsSL https://openclaw.ai/install.sh | bash

# Run onboarding
openclaw onboard --install-daemon

# Verify
openclaw doctor
openclaw gateway status
```

⚠ **DON'T RUN BOTH AT ONCE**

> If you use both the Hub app and WSL2, make sure only one OpenClaw Gateway is running at a time. Both use port 18789 and running them simultaneously will cause conflicts.

OPTION C - QUICK INSTALL

### PowerShell One-Liner

A native Windows install via PowerShell. Less common than the Hub app now, but still supported.

RUN IN POWERSHELL (AS ADMINISTRATOR)

```
iwr -useb https://openclaw.ai/install.ps1 | iex

# Follow the prompts, then run onboarding
openclaw onboard --install-daemon
```

### Preventing Sleep on Windows (Quick Reference)

Once OpenClaw is installed, configure Windows to stay awake using the steps in Section 2. For a quick reference:

```
:: Run in Administrator Command Prompt or PowerShell
:: Disable sleep while plugged in:
powercfg /change standby-timeout-ac 0
powercfg /hibernate off

:: Verify settings applied:
powercfg /query
```

Also go to **Settings → Power & sleep → Additional power settings → Choose what closing the lid does** and set it to **"Do nothing"** when plugged in.

SECTION 07

# Security - What You Must Know Before Installing on a Personal Laptop

This is the most important section in this guide. Installing OpenClaw on a personal laptop - one that also has your banking, personal documents, passwords, and private files - requires extra care.

OpenClaw is not just a chatbot. Depending on how it's configured, it can execute commands, read and modify files, control a browser, and connect to external accounts. That's what makes it powerful. It also means that on a personal laptop, the boundaries between your AI agent and your personal life need to be set deliberately.

🚨 **WHAT COULD POTENTIALLY BE EXPOSED**

An agent with overly broad permissions - or one that encounters a prompt injection attack (malicious instructions hidden in an email or website it reads) - could potentially access personal documents and downloads, browser sessions and saved passwords, connected email or calendar accounts, and sensitive files on your desktop or in your Documents folder.

This doesn't mean OpenClaw automatically accesses these things. It means you need to set boundaries intentionally.

## How to Protect Yourself - Security Checklist

### ✅ 1. Create a Separate Computer Account

The single most effective protection. Create a dedicated, non-administrator user account on your Mac or Windows laptop just for your AI CEO.

- **Mac:** System Settings → Users & Groups → Add Account
- **Windows:** Settings → Accounts → Family & other users → Add someone else

Install and run OpenClaw from that account. Your personal files, browser sessions, and accounts remain in your main account - separated from the agent.

⚠️ **A SEPARATE ACCOUNT HELPS - BUT ISN'T PERFECT**

A separate user account is a good first line of defense, but it's not complete isolation. Incorrectly configured tool permissions, shared folders, or administrative privileges can

weaken that separation. For truly sensitive workloads, a dedicated Mac mini or VPS provides a stronger boundary.

### ✅ 1b. Use Fast User Switching — Never Fully Log Out

Once you have two accounts set up, how you move between them matters. If you **log out** of the AI CEO user account and log into your personal account, your AI CEO stops running. Scheduled tasks pause. Automations stop. The agent goes offline until that account is active again.

**The fix: Fast User Switching.** Both Mac and Windows let you switch between user accounts without logging either one out. Both sessions stay active simultaneously — your AI CEO keeps running in the background while you work freely in your personal account.

> ✅ **THE RULE: SWITCH USER — NEVER LOG OUT**
>
> Always use **Switch User** (not Log Out) when moving between your personal account and your AI CEO account. Fast User Switching keeps both sessions alive at the same time.

#### How to Enable Fast User Switching

**🍎 Mac**

1. **Open System Settings**
   Click the Apple menu → **System Settings**
2. **Go to Control Center**
   In the sidebar, click **Control Center**
3. **Enable Fast User Switching**
   Scroll down to find **Fast User Switching** and set it to show in the Menu Bar (as icon, full name, or short name — your choice)
4. **Switch Users Without Logging Out**
   Click the user icon in the menu bar → select your AI CEO account. To return to your personal account, click the same icon and switch back. Both accounts stay active the entire time.

**🪟 Windows**

1. **Open the Start Menu**
   Click the **Start** button (Windows logo) in the taskbar

2 **Click Your Account Name or Avatar**

At the top or bottom of the Start menu, click your profile picture or account name

3 **Select the Other Account**

You'll see your other user accounts listed. Click the AI CEO account to switch to it — your personal session stays running in the background

4 **Switch Back Anytime**

Repeat the same steps to return to your personal account. Windows keeps both sessions active simultaneously via its built-in Fast User Switching feature (enabled by default).

> 💡 **WHAT HAPPENS WHEN BOTH ARE RUNNING**
>
> When you switch users without logging out, both accounts are active in memory at the same time. Your AI CEO continues processing scheduled tasks, responding to messages, and running automations — even while your screen shows your personal account. Think of it like two desks in the same office: one is in front of you, the other is running quietly behind you.

### ✅ 2. Enable Disk Encryption

- **Mac:** System Settings → Privacy & Security → FileVault → Turn On
- **Windows:** Settings → Privacy & Security → Device Encryption → Turn On

### ✅ 3. Enable OpenClaw Sandboxing

OpenClaw's sandboxing limits which files and commands your agent can access. It is not enabled by default - you need to configure it intentionally. Restrict file access to the agent's workspace and require human approval for anything that reaches beyond it.

### ✅ 4. Restrict API Keys

- Use **restricted API keys** with only the permissions your AI CEO actually needs
- Create separate keys for each service - don't reuse the same key across platforms
- For Stripe and financial accounts: use **read-only access** for reporting; require human approval for anything that moves money
- **Never paste API keys into SOUL.md, AGENTS.md, or other Markdown files** - store them in OpenClaw's secure configuration

### ✅ 5. Use Separate Business Browser Profiles

If your AI CEO uses browser automation, set up a dedicated browser profile for business use only. Do not connect it to your personal banking, password manager, or personal email sessions.

### ✅ 6. Require Approval for Sensitive Actions

Configure your agent to require human approval before any financial transactions, file deletions, or system-level commands. Don't allow unrestricted autonomous action on sensitive systems.

### ✅ 7. Run OpenClaw's Security Audit

```
# Run this after installation and before connecting any sensitive accounts
openclaw security audit --deep

# Review all warnings and address them before going live
```

### ✅ 8. Keep Everything Updated

Keep your operating system, OpenClaw, and Node.js up to date. Security patches matter - especially on a machine connected to business accounts.

## Complete Security Checklist

- ☐ Separate OS user account created for OpenClaw
- ☐ Fast User Switching enabled — using Switch User (not Log Out) to move between accounts
- ☐ Disk encryption enabled (FileVault on Mac / Device Encryption on Windows)
- ☐ OpenClaw sandboxing configured; file access restricted to workspace
- ☐ Restricted API keys in use for all integrations
- ☐ No API credentials in plain-text Markdown files
- ☐ Separate browser profile set up for business/agent use
- ☐ Financial account access is read-only; transaction approval required
- ☐ Human approval required for sensitive actions
- ☐ openclaw security audit --deep completed and warnings addressed
- ☐ OS and OpenClaw kept up to date

SECTION 08

# Laptop vs. Mac mini vs. VPS - Full Comparison

| FACTOR | 💻 LAPTOP | 🖥️ MAC MINI | ☁️ VPS |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Hardware needed** | None - use what you have | $500-$800+ upfront | None upfront - $5-25/mo |
| **Always-on operation** | Only when awake and plugged in - requires manual sleep configuration | Yes - dedicated and always on by design | Yes - 24/7 in the data center |
| **Course compatibility** | MacBook and Windows: both covered in the course (Module 4) | Fully compatible - built for this | Workspace files same; installation different |
| **Setup difficulty** | MacBook: easy. Windows: moderate | Easiest overall - course walks you through it | Moderate to advanced - SSH + Linux |
| **Security considerations** | Most complex - personal data on same machine requires extra precautions | Standard - dedicated separate computer | Requires firewall, SSH hardening, private gateway |
| **Best for** | Learning, getting started, testing - not ideal for production 24/7 use | Most students - tested, recommended, fully supported by course | Tech-comfortable users who want cloud-hosted, no hardware |
| **CyrusHQ experience** | Not personally tested - research-based guidance | This is what we use and stand behind | Not personally tested - research-based guidance |

💡 **OUR RECOMMENDATION**

**Start on your laptop.** Build your AI CEO, learn how it works, explore what it can do. If you find you need it running around the clock, handling sensitive production workflows, or operating without interruption - that's the moment to consider a Mac mini or VPS.

Don't buy hardware before you know you need it. The laptop is a perfectly good place to start.

SECTION 09

## A Note About the Course

The *Build Your AI CEO* course was designed and recorded using a Mac mini. Every terminal walkthrough, every installation step, and every screenshot was created in a macOS environment.

**If you're on a MacBook:** You can follow the course installation steps closely. Once OpenClaw is installed, everything from the workspace setup onward applies directly - the Markdown files, the identity structure, the memory system, all of it.

**If you're on a Windows laptop:** You're fully covered. The course addresses both Mac and Windows in Module 4 — including the Windows .msi installer walkthrough and Windows-specific file paths. Follow the Windows sections of Module 4 for installation, then continue through the rest of the course alongside Mac users.

⚠ OUR HONEST DISCLAIMER

CyrusHQ has not personally tested OpenClaw on a laptop. Our AI CEO (Cyrus) and all of our agents run on Mac mini computers. The information in this guide comes from OpenClaw's official documentation and independent research. We're confident in the quality of that research, but we cannot guarantee your specific experience or troubleshoot platform-specific installation issues. For those, OpenClaw's official documentation and your platform's community resources are your best starting points.

SECTION 10

# Next Steps

### The first thing to do:

Reply to our email and tell us whether you're on a **MacBook or a Windows laptop**. That one answer lets us point you directly to the right resources and confirm whether your laptop's specs are a good fit.

### If you're on a MacBook:

1. Check your RAM and disk space (commands in Section 4)
2. Install OpenClaw using the official installer (Section 5)
3. Configure sleep prevention (Section 2)
4. Set up security (Section 7 checklist) before connecting any business accounts
5. Follow the course from the workspace setup lessons onward

### If you're on a Windows laptop:

1. Check your RAM and disk space (Settings → System)
2. Choose your installation path - Hub app recommended for most (Section 6)
3. Configure sleep prevention (Section 2)
4. Set up security (Section 7 checklist)
5. Follow the course from the workspace/identity setup lessons onward

### Official OpenClaw Resources

| Resource | URL |
|---|---|
| Main documentation | docs.openclaw.ai |
| macOS installation | docs.openclaw.ai/getting-started/installation |
| Windows installation | docs.openclaw.ai/platforms/windows |
| Windows Hub app | docs.openclaw.ai/install/windows |
| Security documentation | docs.openclaw.ai/security |

🙌 **QUESTIONS?**

Reach out anytime. Let us know your laptop type and specs and we'll point you in the right direction. We want you to get your AI CEO up and running confidently - whatever machine you're starting on.

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**CyrusHQ** - Build Your AI CEO

This guide is provided for informational purposes based on OpenClaw's official documentation and independent research.
CyrusHQ has not personally tested an OpenClaw laptop installation and cannot guarantee specific outcomes.
Always refer to docs.openclaw.ai for the most current installation instructions.